the narrative provides glimpses of not-so-positive views of India and Indians.

Among the places Vishwanath visited was Gansu province, widely regarded in China as one of its poorest – at least by Chinese standards. In a revealing aside, Vishwanath reflects on the province and Chinese attitudes to India: 'Gansu is generally considered *luan* – an oft-used Chinese word which narrowly means "chaotic" . . . Of course, it does not help that the average Chinese categorises India as *luan*, too – disordered, chaotic and not given to easy navigation.'[42] Vishwanath describes an encounter with a drunken local official who suddenly asks her, 'Are all Indians as black (dark skinned) as you?' She and the other Chinese at her table try to quell the offensive official 'but then there was no stopping his running tongue as he slid into a nasty diatribe on India as a place of filth and poverty'.[43] In *vino veritas* – in wine, truth? Probably not quite. Vishwanath's encounter is unusual – Indians in China are unlikely to experience something as nakedly racist and derogatory. Yet the episode reveals an element of Chinese attitudes towards India: a *luan* place inhabited by dark-skinned people.

Later in the book, Vishwanath recounts more charming encounters. Among them is one in Inner Mongolia, in the town of Hohhot, with Professor Fun Wen, 'a die-hard fan of Rabindranath Tagore' who emotionally recites Tagore all morning long for her. She later dines with Fun Wen, a sociologist working on India, and the local Party Secretary, a 'dashing' man, and no mere party apparatchik. The functionary is knowledgeable about India and 'effortlessly' turns the conversation to Rahul Gandhi, among other topics.[44] These Chinese are not racist. They are admirers of Indian culture, or they are cool-headed interlocutors interested in India's modern development.

'Strangers Across the Border'

This duality is not uniquely Chinese. Every society harbours ambivalences about other societies. Reshma Patil, the *Hindustan Times* correspondent in